

Fuzix for the Pico Computer

Unix and BBC BASIC on the Pico Computer 2 and 3

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1 Introduction

Fuzix is Alan Cox's compact V7-style Unix. This port makes it a third first-class environment for the Pico Computer, beside MMBasic and MicroPython: a genuine multi-tasking Unix booting from SD card, with a full set of classic utilities — and R. T. Russell's BBC BASIC as its flagship application, complete with BBC graphics modes on the HDMI display, the four-channel BBC sound system on the audio DAC, joystick and analogue inputs, and a spare serial port.

It also compiles on its own. `cc` is a complete C89 toolchain running on the hardware — not a cross-compiler — and it generates native ARM code, so the machine builds its own programs, at its own speed, with no PC involved. `mmbc` puts MMBasic in front of it: an MMBasic program translates to C, compiles, and runs as a native program several times faster than the interpreter it was written for.

One kernel image serves both machines. At boot it probes GP27 for the DS3231's 32 kHz clock (the same test MMBasic and MicroPython use): present means Pico Computer 3, absent means Pico Computer 2. The practical difference is the SD card wiring, handled automatically; the boot banner names the detected board.

Headline specification as configured here:

- CPU at 375 MHz (the XGA-capable clock, as MMBasic uses)
- 340 KB of program RAM managed as 4 KB pages, with the 8 MB PSRAM behind it — up to 64 concurrent processes, and a single process may have about 292 KB of it. A swapped-out process is a PSRAM allocation the size of the process, not a slot on a device, so nothing is reserved for one that does not exist
- Programs get their heap from the PSRAM too, so a BASIC array or a C `malloc` is limited by the 8 MB rather than by the process
- Root filesystem on SD card; the on-board NAND flash holds a recovery system
- 80×40 colour ANSI console on HDMI, mirrored to the USB-C serial port, with USB keyboard support (six layouts)
- Pre-emptive multitasking: a runaway program can always be stopped from the keyboard
- A self-hosted C89 compiler generating native ARM code, and an MMBasic translator in front of it — both run on the machine itself
- MMBasic's own full-screen editor, `mmedit`, so BASIC is written, translated, compiled and run without leaving the machine

1.1 New in v0.10

This release fills in the MMBasic translator's two largest gaps: the rest of the drawing statements, and structures.

- **BOX, RBOX, TRIANGLE and ARC translate.** With **CIRCLE, TEXT** and **MAP** already in, the PicoMite drawing set is now covered. Each primitive is a header of static C functions, one header per primitive, so a compiled program carries only the primitives it actually uses — the compiler discards the rest. The same headers are callable from plain C; the C manual documents them.
- **TYPE ... END TYPE — MMBasic structures.** Nested types, member arrays, structure arrays, **LOCALS**, by-reference parameters, whole-structure assignment, **STRUCT COPY/CLEAR/SWAP**, and **STRUCT(SIZEOF/OFFSET/TYPE)** folded to compile-time constants. The firmware's byte layout is reproduced exactly — sizes, offsets, padding and the length-byte string format — so **STRUCT(SIZEOF "t")** answers the same number here and on a PicoMite, and assigning an over-length string to a **LENGTH n** member raises **String too long** just as the firmware does. Verified side by side against a real PicoMite running the firmware's own structure test suite: every feature implemented here

passes identically there. What does not translate is refused by name rather than mistranslated; the translator chapter lists it.

- **A class of board-only crashes in compiled programs is fixed.** `bcrun` could size a program's memory arena so that the stack ended up misaligned for the ARM's paired-register stores, and the Cortex-M33 faults on those regardless of its unaligned-access support. Neither the host runner nor `qemu` enforces that, so the crash existed only on real hardware. The arena is now rounded so the stack is always 8-byte aligned.
- **ON ERROR SKIP/IGNORE, with `MM.ERRNO` and `MM.ERRMSG$`.** A program can survive an error instead of stopping at it, exactly as it can on a PicoMite — and the errors themselves now fire where the interpreter fires them. That was the larger half of the work: float division by zero used to answer `inf` rather than stopping, `SQR(-1)` and `LOG(0)` answered `nan` and `-inf`, string concatenation past 255 characters truncated instead of erroring, and `ASC("")` errored where a PicoMite returns 0. Each of those was a program that behaved differently here and said nothing about it. There is a section on all of this below.
- **`mmedit` colours the new statements correctly.** `Box`, `RBox`, `Triangle`, `Arc`, `Type`, `End Type`, `Struct` and `Struct(` now show as translatable (cyan) rather than interpreter-only (blue).
- **The kernel's crash report leads with `r4-r7`** — the registers that actually locate the fault in compiled code — so a report copied from the screen is useful even when cut short.

1.2 New in v0.9

This release takes the 32 MB limit off the filesystem and makes compiled code substantially faster.

- **A 2 TB disk format.** Block numbers are 32-bit and inodes 256 bytes, in place of the 16-bit block number that capped a filesystem at 32 MB. The shipped card now has an 800 MB root rather than 32 MB, a single file can reach 1 GB, and the format itself goes to 2 TB. **Old cards and new kernels do not mix:** each refuses the other by name rather than misreading it, so flash the kernel and write the card in the same sitting.
- **Compiled code is over 60% faster.** Dhrystone 2.1, compiled on the machine, went from 102,842 to 166,834 per second — 44% of the same benchmark cross-compiled by `gcc -O2` for this chip. Almost none of that came from generating cleverer instructions; it came from *keeping hot code native*. Library symbols are bound once at load instead of being looked up on every call, the hottest local in a function is held in a register, and compound assignment on 64-bit and double values is inlined rather than calling out to the runtime — that last one had been costing every MMBasic `FOR` loop a crossing out of native code on every single iteration.
- **The console survives a lost UART interrupt.** Three console wedges during large serial transfers shared one state: the interrupt enabled and pending, but never delivered. Why delivery is lost is still not understood, but it is no longer fatal — the handler now drains both directions and the 5 ms tick is a full polled rescue, so the console degrades to polled instead of dying.
- **`vi`.** The editor has always been on the card, but only under its own name, `levee`. It now answers to `vi` as well: one file, two names, no extra space.
- **`mmedit`'s function keys work from a serial terminal.** They always worked from a USB keyboard on the HDMI console, but a terminal such as TeraTerm spells F1–F4 differently — `ESC [ 11 ~` where the console sends `ESC O P` — and the editor silently ignored the spelling it did not know. Since the editor is driven almost entirely by function keys, that made it close to unusable over the serial port. It now accepts every sequence MMBasic's own `MMInkey` accepts, including the shifted forms.
- **`INKEY$` returns MMBasic's key codes.** A terminal sends an arrow or a function key as a several-byte escape sequence; MMBasic hands back one code for it, and until now a translated program here saw the raw bytes one at a time instead. So `IF INKEY$ = CHR$(&H80)` — the way

every PicoMite program tests for cursor-up — quietly never matched. `INKEY$` now reassembles the sequence and returns the same single code the PicoMite does: `&H80–&H83` for the cursor keys, `&H91–&H9C` for F1–F12, and the editing cluster besides. Anything it does not recognise is handed back byte by byte, as before, so nothing is swallowed.

- **vi can edit a real file.** Levee shipped with a 4 KB buffer — a fair share of an 8-bit micro, and not of this machine. It is now 64 KB.

1.3 New in v0.8

This release gives the machine music, pins, and MMBasic's own text.

- **MP3 playback.** `PLAY MP3 f$` plays a file *while your program carries on running* — the decoder is a separate process feeding a deep buffer in the kernel, so nothing has to be refilled from a main loop. `PLAY VOLUME n` sets the level and is remembered; `PLAY STOP` stops whatever is playing, including a player left behind by a program you interrupted. A translated BASIC benchmark still runs at **89% of full speed** with music playing.
- **SETPIN and PIN** — all forty-eight GPIOs of the RP2350B, not the 28 an RP2040 has. `SETPIN n, DIN|DOUT, PIN(n) = v` and the `PIN(n)` function.
- **TEXT, FONT and all nine of MMBasic's fonts**, held in flash so they cost no RAM at all. `TEXT` takes the full alignment and scale arguments.
- **MAP, statement and function**, with `CLS [colour]`: the sixteen colours can be remapped exactly as in MMBasic, and the defaults are now MMBasic's own HDMI values rather than an approximation.
- **PAUSE gives the CPU up** instead of spinning, so a program that waits no longer holds the machine — and the fraction of a second it cannot sleep is bounded at 99 ms however long the pause.
- **Programs are much smaller.** MMBasic's scratch memory is now sized per program rather than fixed, taking a translated program's static data from 61,904 bytes to 12,748.
- **Maths runs on the DCP.** `SIN`, `COS`, `EXP` and the rest are shared out of kernel flash and use the RP2350's double-precision co-processor: about **2.7× faster** than the copy that used to be linked into every program, and it costs no program memory.
- **A C library fix that reaches everything.** `<limits.h>` declared `INT_MAX` as 32767 on a machine whose `int` is 32 bits. Any program that compared against it — or sized a buffer with it — was working from a number two thousand times too small. Every binary on the card has been rebuilt.

The kernel and the card are a matched pair, as always: the card's programs are statically linked, so a new kernel with an old card runs the old C library.

1.4 New in v0.7

Most of the kernel now executes from flash instead of being copied into RAM at boot, and the memory that frees goes to programs.

- **340 KB of program RAM**, up from 312, and a single process can have about **292 KB**. 90,676 bytes of kernel code used to be copied into RAM at boot; 45,000 of them are gone, and what is left has room to grow. Costs nothing measurable: the display DMAs out of RAM continuously, so RAM bandwidth is contended while the flash cache is a separate path.
- **64 processes**, up from 30, with the open-file and inode tables sized to match — the shell gives every background job its own `/dev/null`, so the file table ran dry before the process table did.

- **FRAMEBUFFER** — `CREATE`, `WRITE N|F`, `COPY s,d[,B]`, `CLOSE`, `WAIT`. Draw off-screen and show the frame in one go. A redraw-and-show frame costs about 4.4 ms against the 17 ms the display gives you, and `COPY ... ,B` holds a loop to the refresh rate.
- **PRINT @(x, y [, mode])** puts text at a pixel position. In a graphics mode `PRINT` now *draws* the characters, as MMBasic does, rather than sending them to the console — so text follows the drawing into the framebuffer instead of the console scrolling the display out from under it. `mode 1` draws over what is there, 2 swaps ink and paper.
- **INKEY\$** — which was not implemented at all, and because it ends in `$` was quietly being treated as an ordinary empty string variable, so `LOOP UNTIL INKEY$ <> ""` could never exit.
- **PIXEL x(), y(), c()** — the array form, one call for a whole run of points instead of one syscall each.
- **Text scrolls the same way everywhere.** A `PRINT` on the last line scrolls in a graphics mode exactly as it does on the console, because it is now literally the same code.
- **A stretched ellipse outline is no longer dotted** — the fix from MMBasic's own `DrawCircle`.
- **PRINT "x"; reaches the screen.** A partial line used to sit in a buffer until the next newline, so a program printing “Calculating...” and then working for half a minute showed nothing until it finished.
- **BBC BASIC works again.** It sizes its workspace by asking for memory until the kernel refuses; v0.6 let it take every last block, leaving the shell nowhere to return to. A process may now grow only as far as leaves room for the largest other one.
- **The boot banner names the PC3 release**, alongside Fuzix's own version — they are different numbers, and only one of them used to be on screen.

1.5 New in v0.6

This release is about memory. A translated BASIC program could not hold a framebuffer-sized array, and a large one could not be loaded at all; both are fixed, and the same work made everything faster.

- **BASIC arrays and strings live in the PSRAM heap.** They used to sit in the 48 KB the interpreter gave a program, so a 38,400 byte array — one `MODE 1` framebuffer — did not fit at all. Globals go in one block taken once; `LOCAL` arrays and strings get a block per invocation, freed on the way out, which is what makes recursion correct. Simple variables stay where they are: they are the hot ones, and SRAM is 3.7× faster to reach than PSRAM.
- **Programs are 15% faster.** A program address is now a machine address rather than an offset into a 48 KB window, so every access stops paying for the conversion. The solar eclipse went from 3.31 to 2.80 seconds, and the heap change above costs about half a percent on top.
- **A process may use all of program RAM.** The old 256 KB ceiling was the size of a fixed swap slot, and swap has not worked that way for a while.
- **SYSTEM, SAVE IMAGE and LOAD IMAGE work from large programs again.** `fork` needed the process resident twice over, so anything past half of memory could not do it. The parent is now staged into PSRAM instead.
- **A memory leak fixed** that cost 132 KB — of 312 KB — every time a program failed to start, for the rest of that boot.
- **A C library bug fixed** that made `fread` and `fseek` disagree about a file's position and quietly return the wrong bytes. It needed a file small enough to fit one buffer, which is why it went unnoticed: it took down the compiler on a 305-byte object while 100 KB ones were fine. It is not specific to this machine and has been reported upstream.

1.6 New in v0.5

- **MMBasic draws.** `MODE`, `COLOUR`, `PIXEL`, `LINE`, `CIRCLE` and `RGB()` are translated and run on the HDMI display — a whole shape crosses into the kernel in one call, so a 640-point line costs one syscall rather than 640.
- **SAVE IMAGE and LOAD IMAGE**, with MMBasic's BMP decoder: 1/4/8/16/24/32-bit files, RLE4 and RLE8, and its dithering modes.
- **SYSTEM** — a BASIC program can run another program and wait for it, which is how `SAVE IMAGE` and `LOAD IMAGE` are built.
- **mmedit**, MMBasic's editor, ported.
- **TIMER is a float** off a 64-bit microsecond clock, and **RND returns 53 bits** from `splitmix64` rather than 15 from the C library.
- The SD root filesystem is now **built from source** by `mksdimage.sh` — it had no build recipe before — and is **64000 blocks** rather than the 65535 that sat on `blkno_t`'s ceiling.
- A **filesystem corruption fixed** that had been destroying cards under repeated large-file rewrites: `f_trunc` freed a file's double indirect block and left the inode still pointing at it. It bit any file over 273 blocks. See the release notes.
- **Panic messages now reach the serial port.** They were being truncated to about eleven characters by an interrupt-driven UART that stopped with the machine.

2 Installing Fuzix

2.1 Flashing the kernel

The kernel is a standard UF2 file, `fuzix.uf2`, flashed exactly like any other Pico Computer firmware:

1. Set the USB HUB switch to **DISABLE** and connect the **Prog** port to your PC.
2. Hold **BOOT**, click **RESET**, release **BOOT**. A USB drive appears.
3. Drag `fuzix.uf2` onto the drive. The board reboots when the copy completes.
4. Set the HUB switch back to **ENABLE**.

Flashing does not touch the SD card.

2.2 Writing the SD card

Fuzix boots from a ready-made card image, `pc3-sd.img` (978 MB, about 4.9 MB compressed for download). Write it to a card of **1 GB or larger** with any raw-image tool — Raspberry Pi Imager (“use custom image”), Win32DiskImager, balenaEtcher, or `dd` on Linux/macOS. **The whole card is overwritten.**

The image lays the card out as three partitions:

Partition	Size	Type	Purpose
1	128 MB	FAT	File interchange with Windows/macOS/Linux
2	800 MB	Fuzix root	The Unix filesystem (boot device <code>hdb2</code>)
3	4 MB	0x7F	Reserved

The root filesystem is 1,638,400 blocks of 512 bytes with 25,600 inodes, and it fills its partition exactly.

It did not always. Before v0.9 a block number was 16 bits, so 65535 was at once the highest block a filesystem could have and the marker meaning “no such block” — and the filesystem was deliberately held to 64000 blocks, short of its own partition, so that a stray value could be recognised as wrong instead of pointing at a real sector. That is what limited the root to 32 MB. From v0.9 the format is **FS32**: 32-bit block numbers and 256-byte inodes, with a “no such block” marker that cannot be a real block at all. The margin is gone, and with it the ceiling — a filesystem can now be up to 2 TB and a single file up to 1 GB.

A v0.9 kernel and a v0.9 card go together. The two formats are not interchangeable and neither pretends otherwise: a v0.9 kernel refuses an older card by name at the `bootdev:` prompt, and an older kernel refuses a v0.9 one. Flash `fuzix.uf2` and write the card in the same sitting.

Since v0.5 the filesystem has been built from source by `mksdimage.sh`, so the card can be reproduced rather than merely copied. `mkcard.sh` decides the layout, and its `FAT_MB` and `ROOT_MB` settings are the only place the partition sizes are written down.

Partition 1 ships unformatted: format it as **FAT or FAT32 (not exFAT)** in Windows before first use — see section 6. Partition 2 is Fuzix’s own filesystem format; no desktop OS can mount it, which is why the FAT partition and the `fat` command exist.

2.3 First boot

Connect a monitor to the HDMI port and/or a terminal program (for example TeraTerm at 115200) to the USB-C console port. Switch on: the kernel banner, board identification and device probe appear on

both, then:

```
login: root
```

There is no password. The system arrives at a Bourne shell; the console is an 80×40 colour terminal (termcap type `pc3`) and the USB keyboard and serial input feed the same session interchangeably. Set the keyboard layout in `/etc/rc` (`picotcl keymap uk` by default).

To power off, type `shutdown` (or at minimum `sync`, then wait a moment). After an unclean power-off the next boot repairs the filesystem automatically (`fsck -a -y`).

2.4 Setting the clock

The board's DS3231 battery-backed clock supplies the date and time: at every boot `/etc/rc` runs `setdate`, which reads the chip and sets system time silently. If the chip cannot supply a valid time (fresh battery, or the battery was removed) the same command falls back to prompting on the console:

```
Current date is Mon 2026-07-27
Enter new date:
```

Press Enter to keep a value, or type a new one (2026-07-28, then 16:30:00). To set the clock at any other time run `setdate -u`, which always prompts.

Setting the system time does not touch the chip. To make the time permanent, write it back:

```
# setdate -w
writing
```

That also restarts a stopped oscillator, so the sequence for a new battery is: `setdate -u` (enter the time), then `setdate -w`. The kernel message `oscillator was stopped, time needs setting` at boot means exactly that sequence is wanted.

While running, system time is kept by the crystal-driven timer tick and gently re-synchronised from the DS3231 about once an hour, the same policy as MMBasic. `date` prints the current time.

If a transaction to the chip is ever interrupted at the wrong moment (a reset mid-read), the battery-backed DS3231 can be left jamming the I2C bus - even across power cycles. The kernel detects this at boot (`ds3231: SDA held low, clocking bus free`) and clears it automatically.

2.5 Command history and line editing

At any cooked-mode prompt - the shell, login, most line-oriented programs - the console provides in-line editing and command history:

Key	Action
Up / Down	walk back / forward through previous commands
Left / Right	move within the line
Home / End (or Ctrl-A / Ctrl-E)	start / end of line
Backspace / Delete	delete left / at the cursor
Ctrl-U	discard the line

The history (about 500 commands) lives in a small region reserved at the top of the PSRAM, so it costs no program memory; like the RAM disc it survives a reset but not a power cycle. Programs that take

the terminal raw (BBC BASIC, the editor) see every keystroke themselves as usual - BBC BASIC has its own line editor and *EDIT.

2.6 Escape routes

- **Esc** — inside BBC BASIC, stops the running program.
- **Ctrl-** — kernel emergency break: kills the foreground program even if it has the terminal in raw mode, and restores a sane terminal. Use it instead of the RESET button when something wedges.
- **kill** from the shell works on anything; Fuzix pre-emption guarantees a spinning process can't lock you out.

3 The consoles

Everything is mirrored: kernel and program output appear on the HDMI display and the serial console simultaneously, and input is merged from the USB keyboard and the serial line. TeraTerm is resized to 80×40 automatically at boot.

While BBC BASIC has a graphics MODE on screen, the HDMI display belongs to the graphics; text output continues to the serial side as a plain stream, so a transcript survives even a full-screen game.

4 BBC BASIC

Start it by name; leave with QUIT:

```
# bbcbasic
BBC BASIC for Fuzix Console v0.50
(C) Copyright R. T. Russell, 2025
>
```

This is R. T. Russell’s BBC BASIC (the BBCSDL console edition), so the language is the full modern dialect: 64-bit integers, IEEE double floats, long variable names, **WHILE/ENDWHILE**, multi-line **IF/ELSE/ENDIF**, structures, and the inline assembler. Keywords must be typed in **capitals** (**PRINT**, not **print**); ***LOWERCASE ON** relaxes this. Star commands are case-insensitive.

4.1 Loading programs, including plain text

LOAD and **CHAIN** accept **both** program formats:

- the tokenised internal format written by **SAVE** (fast, exact), and
- **plain ASCII listings**, detected automatically. An unnumbered modern-style listing is given line numbers 10, 20, 30...; a listing with its own numbers keeps them. Windows line endings are fine, and typographic characters that desktop editors introduce (curly quotes, non-breaking spaces, tabs) are silently converted to their ASCII equivalents — an invisible “smart” character can otherwise produce a baffling **Syntax error** on a line that looks perfect.

The comfortable round trip: edit **myprog.bas** on your PC, copy it to the FAT partition, then:

```
# fat get myprog.bas
# bbcbasic
>LOAD "myprog.bas"
>RUN
>SAVE "MYPROG"          save tokenised for fast loading next time
```

4.2 Graphics

MODE 0–5 switch the display to 1024×768 and provide the classic screens; **MODE** with any higher number (e.g. **MODE** 6) returns to the text console. Errors leave you at the prompt *in* the current mode, exactly like the original machine.

MODE	Resolution	Colours	Presentation on the monitor
0, 3	640×256	2	Full width (5:8 smooth upscale), full height
1, 4	320×256	4	960×768 — every pixel a crisp 3×3 block
2, 5	160×256	16	960×768 — every pixel a crisp 6×3 block

Coordinates are the authentic 1280×1024 graphics units, origin bottom-left, movable with **VDU** 29. Implemented: **MOVE**, **DRAW**, **PLOT** (move/line families 0–15, points 64–71, filled triangles 80–87 — so **PLOT** 85 works), **CLG**, **GCOL**, **COLOUR**, **POINT(x,y)**, **VDU** 19 palette changes (instant, no redraw), **TAB(x,y)**, and text printed with the built-in 8×8 font (40 or 80 columns × 32 rows, with scrolling). **MODE** 1/4 store 4 bits per pixel, so all 16 logical colours are available there via **VDU** 19 even though the default palette is the authentic four.

4.3 Sound

The full BBC sound system plays through the PCM5102 DAC and the 3.5 mm jack:

```
SOUND 1,-15,89,20          A4 (440 Hz) for one second
ENVELOPE 1,1,4,-4,4,10,10,10,126,-2,0,-10,120,100
SOUND 1,1,100,30           envelope-shaped note
SOUND &101,-15,53,20:SOUND &102,-15,69,20:SOUND &103,-15,81,20
                           a synchronised C-E-G chord
```

Channels 1–3 are square-wave tones, channel 0 is noise. Each channel queues up to 8 notes; `&1x` in the channel number flushes the queue, `&1xx–&3xx` synchronise channels. `ENVELOPE` implements the three-section pitch envelope and ADSR amplitude, stepped at the authentic 100 Hz. Pitch follows the BBC scale: 4 units per semitone, 89 = A4 = 440 Hz. Durations are in 20ths of a second; 255 means “until further notice”. `SOUND` blocks BBC-style when a queue is full (Esc still works).

There is one audio output, so the synthesiser and MP3 playback are mutually exclusive — as they are in MMBasic. While a track is playing, notes are queued and heard when it ends; `PLAY STOP`, or killing `playmp3`, gives the synthesiser the hardware back at once.

4.4 ADVAL: joystick, analogue inputs, sound queues

Call	Returns
ADVAL(0)	Joystick switches on GP34–37 as a mask: bit 0 = GP34, bit 1 = GP35, bit 2 = GP36, bit 3 = GP37; pressed (grounded) = 1
ADVAL(1)–ADVAL(4)	Analogue readings of GP41–GP44, 0–65520 (12-bit ADC × 16)
ADVAL(-1)	Characters waiting in the keyboard buffer
ADVAL(-5)–ADVAL(-8)	Free queue slots on sound channels 0–3
ADVAL(-9)	Hardware microsecond counter (64-bit)

The joystick inputs have pull-ups and Schmitt-trigger inputs enabled; wire switches directly to ground. The analogue inputs are 3.3 V full-scale.

ADVAL(-9) is the benchmarking clock — the RP2350’s free-running microsecond timer, far finer than `TIME`’s centiseconds (which tick in tenths of a second on this kernel). MMBasic-style usage:

```
DEF FNtimer = ADVAL(-9)
T% = FNtimer
REM ... code under test ...
PRINT (FNtimer - T%) / 1000; " ms"
```

Each reading costs one system call (a few tens of microseconds) - negligible over millisecond-scale measurements. The value is the full 64-bit hardware counter (BBC BASIC integers are 64-bit), counting microseconds since power-on: it never wraps in practice.

4.5 Serial port

A second serial port lives on the I/O header: **TX = GP0**, **RX = GP1** (3.3 V logic, no flow control), visible as `/dev/tty2`. BBC BASIC reaches it as a *port channel* — raw and unbuffered:

```
*stty 9600 </dev/tty2
ch% = OPENUP("/dev/tty2")
```

BPUT#ch%,65	send a byte
X% = BGET#ch%	receive a byte (waits for one)
CLOSE#ch%	

Any `stty` setting applies (baud rate, parity, size). The same `OPENIN/OPENUP/BGET#/BPUT#` mechanism works on any `/dev` device; ordinary file names get the buffered 256-byte file channels instead, exactly as on the original machine.

4.6 Star commands and the shell

The built-in set includes `*DIR/*. , *CD, *TYPE, *COPY, *DELETE/*ERA, *MKDIR, *RMDIR, *KEY, *SPOOL, *EXEC, *LOWERCASE, *TEMPO, *QUIT`. Anything unrecognised is passed to the Unix shell, so `*ls -l, *stty 9600 </dev/tty2` and even `*fat get demo.bas` work from inside BASIC.

4.7 The inline assembler

The assembler between `[` and `]` targets the machine it runs on: **ARM Thumb (v6-M subset)**, not 6502. `CALL` and `USR` work as documented for BBCSDL's ARM editions. Machine code written for a BBC Micro will not run; this is the same situation as every modern BBC BASIC.

4.8 Differences from the original BBC Micro

Better than the original:

- ~110 KB of program workspace (about 80 KB when graphics are in use) against the Model B's 32 KB shared with the screen
- 64-bit integers, double-precision floats, the modern language
- Long file names on a hierarchical filesystem
- The machine multitasks underneath — BASIC is just a process

Not (yet) present, compared with an original machine or full BBCSDL:

- **MODE 7** teletext (MODE 6 and 7 return to the console)
- **VDU 5** text-at-the-graphics-cursor; user-defined characters (**VDU 23**) are accepted but not rendered
- **PLOT** families beyond points/lines/triangles: no circles, arcs, ellipses, flood fill or rectangle/parallelogram fills yet
- **GCOL** action modes 1–4 (**OR/AND/EOR/invert**) plot as mode 0 (set)
- Flashing colours (8–15 map to their steady equivalents)
- ***FX** calls, **INKEY** with negative arguments (keyboard scanning), and the 6502 **CALL** interface
- **TIME** advances in 0.1 s steps (the kernel clock granularity)
- Cassette/Econet/ROM filing systems, for obvious reasons

5 The C compiler

The machine compiles C on its own, with no PC involved. `cc` is Alan Cox's Fuzix Compiler Kit, retargeted here to a bytecode machine.

```
# cat > hello.c
#include <stdio.h>

int main(void)
{
    printf("hello from Fuzix\n");
    return 0;
}
^D
# cc hello.c
# ./hello.bc
hello from Fuzix
```

`cc prog.c` writes `prog.bc` and makes it executable, so `./prog.bc` runs it directly — the object starts with `#!/usr/bin/bcrun`, and the kernel does the rest. `bcrun prog.bc` still works and is the way to run an object that has lost its execute bit. Options are `-o name`, `-v` to show each pass as it runs, and `-k` to keep the intermediates. `bcdump prog.bc` disassembles.

`cc` is a driver: it runs `cpp`, then the three compiler passes from `/usr/lib/cc`. The passes cannot be driven from the shell by hand — two of them read back from their own standard output, which needs a redirection the Bourne shell here does not have. Like BBC BASIC, the compiler lives on the SD card root and is not in the NAND recovery system.

A small program takes about a second to compile. The dots `cc` prints are progress, one per top-level declaration.

5.1 What it compiles

C89, plus declarations after statements — the one C99 borrowing, because refusing it is a nuisance out of proportion to the standard it comes from. Everything else is ANSI C as of 1989: the full type system, `struct` and `union` including passing and returning them by value, `enum`, `typedef`, function pointers, `switch`, `goto`, all the usual operators, 64-bit `long long`, and double-precision floating point.

The compiler is checked against gcc as an oracle: 165 of the 175 applicable tests in the public `c-testsuite` conformance suite pass with byte-identical output, and a set of samples in the source tree is diffed against gcc on every change — on the board as well as on the host.

5.2 Headers and the runtime library

`/usr/lib/cc/include` holds `stdio.h`, `stdlib.h`, `string.h`, `math.h`, `assert.h`, `limits.h` and `stddef.h`. These describe what `bcrun` actually provides, and they are deliberately **not** `/usr/include`, which describes the Fuzix C library used by native binaries.

Available: `printf sprintf puts putchar`; `fopen fclose fread fwrite fgetcgetc fputcputc fgets fputs fprintf feof fseek ftell rewind fflush remove`; `malloc calloc realloc free exit atoi abs`; `strlen strcpy strncpy strcat strcmp strncmp strchr strrchr memset memcpy memmove memcmp`; and from `math.h`, in double precision, `sin cos tan asin acos atan atan2 sinh cosh tanh sqrt exp`

`log log10 pow floor ceil fabs fmod`. Each of those is a native function inside `bcrun`, so it runs at machine speed whatever the calling code is.

`malloc` takes its memory from the PSRAM, not from the program's own 340 KB, so a C program can allocate far more than it could hold itself. It is asked for once when the program loads; set `BCRUN_HEAP` to a size in KB in the environment to change how much.

The raw system calls `open creat close read write lseek unlink` are also linked in, but no header declares them — declare them yourself if you want them. Two extras reach the hardware: `time_us()` returns the microsecond counter, and `adval(n)` is the BASIC `ADVAL` function (joystick, analogue inputs, sound queues).

5.3 Limitations

These are worth knowing before you start a large program.

- **One source file per program.** There is no assembler and no linker: `cc2` writes a loadable object directly, so nothing can be linked together. `cc` rejects a second source file rather than pretending.
- **Bitfields are not implemented.** `unsigned flags : 3;` is refused with a diagnostic. This is the only part of C89 missing.
- **& on a library function does not work.** A runtime function is resolved by index and has no address, so `&printf` cannot be represented. `bcrun` refuses such a program by name when it loads it, rather than running it with something wrong in place of an address. Pointers to *your own* functions are entirely fine.
- **No wide strings.** `L'x'` is accepted (and equals `'x'` here); `L"..."` is refused rather than quietly returned as a narrow array.
- **printf rounds halves up.** `%.2f` of 0.125 gives 0.13 where a full C library gives 0.12. A deliberate, documented difference: matching the round-half-to-even rule needs exact decimal expansion.

5.4 Speed

`cc2` translates each function it compiles into native Thumb-2 for the Cortex-M33 and stores that in the object beside the bytecode; `bcrun` runs the native code and keeps the interpreter for whatever did not translate. Nothing needs to be asked for — it is simply what the compiler does.

Dhrystone 2.1, compiled on the machine, runs at about **167,000 Dhrystones/second** — 44% of the same benchmark cross-compiled by `gcc -O2` for the same chip (379,000). Individual loops do better: a sieve, a shell sort and an xorshift generator all land within a factor of two or three of `gcc`, and double-precision arithmetic uses the RP2350's hardware co-processor through the same routines the rest of the system uses.

That figure has moved a long way and is still moving: the same benchmark ran at 3,808/second on the original pure interpreter and 90,000 as recently as v0.8. Most of the recent ground came from keeping the hot code in native form rather than from generating better instructions — binding every library symbol once at load, caching the hottest local in a register, and inlining the compound assignments (`i += n`) on the 64-bit and double types that every MMBasic loop counter uses. Each of those had been quietly leaving native code and crossing back into the C runtime once per iteration.

A program can be forced to interpret with `BCRUN_BYTECODE=1` in the environment, which is how the native code is checked against the interpreter — the two must agree exactly.

What the compiler is *for* is being able to write and build real programs on the machine itself — utilities,

file handling, glue, and now whole applications where the speed matters. Nothing else on the Pico Computer can do it: this is a complete toolchain that runs on the hardware, not a cross-compiler.

The bytecode is also a deliberately language-neutral intermediate form, so front ends for other languages can share the same back end and runtime. `mmbc`, the MMBasic translator described next, is the first.

6 MMBasic: the `mmbc` translator

`mmbc` translates an MMBasic program into C. `cc` compiles that C into native ARM code. The result runs as an ordinary program, several times faster than the same source under the MMBasic interpreter, on the same machine at the same clock.

Nothing about it is a cross-development trick: both programs live on the SD card and run on the Pico Computer.

6.1 The three commands

```
# mmbc prog.bas      -> prog.c
# cc prog.c          -> prog.bc
# ./prog.bc          runs it
```

`mmbc` writes `prog.c` next to the source and says so. `-o name.c` puts it somewhere else. Every line it cannot translate is reported with its line number and left as a comment in the C, so a program that uses something unsupported still produces a translation you can read, and tells you exactly where it gave up.

On the machine, `mmbc` writes C for the machine's own compiler. On a host it writes the slightly different C that `gcc` prefers; `--fcc` and `--gcc` force either form, which only matters if you are moving the generated C between the two.

6.2 A first program

```
# cat > hello.bas
Print "Hello from MMBasic"
For i = 1 To 5
  Print i, i * i
Next i
^D
# mmbc hello.bas
wrote hello.c
# cc hello.c
....
# ./hello.bc
Hello from MMBasic
1      1
2      4
3      9
4     16
5     25
```

The dots from `cc` are one per top-level declaration — a translated program carries the MMBasic runtime's declarations with it, so there are a couple of hundred of them even for four lines of BASIC. That is also why the first compile takes longer than the size of your program suggests: about half a minute here, and much the same for anything small.

`Print` with a comma gives MMBasic's tabbed columns, as above.

6.3 A worked example: the KnivD benchmark

This is a published MMBasic benchmark, unmodified. It runs four thirty-second rounds and reports a score.

```
# cat bench.bas
Print "MMBASIC benchmark (C) KnivD 2016"
Dim integer t, i=0
Dim float x(1000), f=0.0
Dim string s=""
Print "Calculating... ";
count%=0
Do
  s=""
  f=0.0
  i=0
  Timer =0
  Do While Timer<30000
    i=i+2 : f=f+2.0002
    If (i Mod 2)=0 Then
      i=i*2 : i=i\2
      f=f*2.0002 : f=f/2.0002
    End If
    i=i-1
    For t=1 To 100
      f=f-1.0001
      If (f-Int(f))>=0.5 Then
        f=Sin(f*Log(i))
        s=Str$(f,6,6)
      End If
      f=(f-Tan(i))*(Rnd(0)/i)
      If Instr(s,LEFT$(Str$(i),2))>0 Then s=s+"0"
    Next
    x(1+(i Mod 1000))=f
  Loop
  Print Chr$(13)+"Performance: "+Str$((i*1024)\286,8,0)+" grains"
  Inc count%
Loop Until count%=4
End

# mmbc bench.bas
wrote bench.c
# cc bench.c
.....
# ./bench.bc
MMBASIC benchmark (C) KnivD 2016
Calculating... Performance:      28944 grains
Performance:      28944 grains
Performance:      28944 grains
Performance:      28940 grains
```

MMBasic itself scores about 12,000 grains on the same board at the same clock. Note what the program exercises: 64-bit integers, doubles, string building, **Str\$**, **Instr**, **Sin**, **Log**, **Tan**, **Rnd**, a thousand-element array and a timer — all of it translated, compiled and running natively.

6.4 A worked example: something numerical

A longer one. `solar_eclipse.bas`, in `/root/cc`, is a 3,200-line astronomical calculation (Bessel elements, lunar and solar series) that reads a date and prints the circumstances of an eclipse. It is a good test because every digit of its output can be checked against other machines.

```
# mmbc solar_eclipse.bas
wrote solar_eclipse.c
# ./solar_eclipse.bc < solar_eclipse.in
...
event duration          2.61100904 hours
Time taken :           2.803 Seconds
```

The same program takes 12.5 seconds under MMBasic and 8.8 seconds under MicroPython on this hardware; every digit printed is identical in all three. Translating it takes a few seconds. Compiling it is a much longer job than the benchmark above — it is a hundred and forty kilobytes of C — so start it when you have the machine to yourself.

6.5 What the translation looks like

The C is meant to be read. Variables keep their names, control flow keeps its shape, and the MMBasic semantics that C does not share — integer division, **Mod** on negative numbers, string handling, the 64-bit integer/double type rules — are handled by a small runtime inside `bcrun` rather than by rewriting your program into something unrecognisable.

```
# mmbc hello.bas
# head -20 hello.c
```

is worth doing once, to see what your program became.

6.6 Strings, arrays and functions

Strings are MMBasic strings: `Dim string s` gives the usual 255 characters, and `Dim string s length 40` the shorter form. Arrays index from `OPTION BASE` as they should, and `Bound()` reports their limits. `Sub` and `Function` work, including arrays passed by reference and modified in place.

Arrays and strings live in the PSRAM heap, so what limits them is the 8 MB rather than the size of a process. A framebuffer-sized array — `Dim Integer fb(4800)`, 38,408 bytes — is unremarkable now; before v0.6 it would not fit at all. Simple variables stay in the program's own memory, where they are quicker to reach, which is the same split MMBasic itself makes and for the same reason.

LOCAL arrays and strings get their own block for each call, released when the routine returns, so a recursive routine sees its own copy at every level. **STATIC** locals are unaffected — they are meant to outlive the call, so they stay where they were.

The one thing to remember is that a translated program is a *program*, not an interactive session: there is no editor, no **RUN**, no immediate mode. You edit the `.bas` file, translate, compile and run — which is also why a translated program can be put in `/usr/bin` and used like any other command.

6.7 Errors

mmbc reports what it could not translate, by line, and carries on:

```
# mmbc gpio.bas
2 line(s) could not be translated and were commented out:
  line 2: expected '='
  line 3: 'pin' is not an array
wrote gpio.c
```

The reasons are the translator's own — it reads `SetPin GP1, DOUT` as far as it can and then says what it wanted to see — so they name the symptom rather than the statement. The lines themselves appear in the C as comments, with the original text, which is the quickest way to see what was dropped:

```
/*      SetPin GP1 , DOUT */
```

The translation still happens and everything else works. `--strict` stops on the first such line instead, and `--report` lists them again at the end along with any implied global variables.

Appendix C lists what is covered.

6.8 Graphics

A translated program draws on the HDMI display with MMBasic's own statements:

```
MODE 2
COLOUR RGB(YELLOW)
LINE 0, 0, 319, 239
CIRCLE 160, 120, 60, , , RGB(WHITE), RGB(BLUE)
PIXEL 10, 10, RGB(RED)
```

Two modes are available, chosen to match the VGA builds of MMBasic and the first two HDMI modes:

MODE	Resolution	Colours
MODE 1	640×480	monochrome
MODE 2	320×240	16, from MMBasic's RGB121 set

`RGB()` takes the usual named colours and `RGB(r,g,b)`. `COLOUR` sets the current drawing colour, which every statement uses when no colour is given. `LINE`, `CIRCLE` and the rest take MMBasic's argument order, including the blank arguments — `CIRCLE x, y, r, , , fill` is written exactly as MMBasic writes it.

The drawing primitives live in headers as static functions, one header per primitive — `mmb_gfx_circle.h`, `mmb_gfx_box.h`, `mmb_gfx_rbox.h`, `mmb_gfx_triangle.h`, `mmb_gfx_arc.h`, `mmb_gfx_text.h`, `mmb_gfx_map.h`, over the shared batch helpers in `mmb_gfx_pts.h` — and the translator includes exactly the ones the program uses, so a program that never draws a circle does not carry the circle code. (cc discards a file-scope static nothing calls, but that rule counts names rather than reachability, so a recursive primitive survives inside any header that carries it — which is why the include, not the static, is the unit that matters.) And a whole shape crosses into the kernel in a single call, so a 640-point line is one syscall, not 640 — measured at 71 µs against 433 µs for the naive version.

The geometry is MMBasic's, copied rather than re-derived, down to the dotted appearance of a stretched ellipse. If a picture differs from MMBasic's, that is a bug worth reporting.

One caution. In `MODE 1` the console and the graphics share a single framebuffer, so anything printed — including the cursor — appears on the picture. It is visible in a `SAVE IMAGE` of the whole screen as a difference in the top text line. Restricting the saved region avoids it; directing program output elsewhere is planned.

6.9 The sixteen colours: `MAP`

`MODE 2` stores a colour *number* per pixel, 0 to 15, and `MAP` says what colour each number actually is. Change entry 8 and everything already drawn in colour 8 changes with it — without redrawing a single pixel. That is what makes fades, flashes and colour cycling free.

```
MAP(4) = RGB(255, 128, 0)      ' collect
MAP SET                        ' ... and apply, all at once
```

<code>MAP(n) = colour</code>	set entry <code>n</code> , 0 to 15. Nothing changes yet
<code>MAP SET</code>	apply the collected palette, during the frame blanking
<code>MAP RESET</code>	back to the mode's own sixteen
<code>MAP MAXIMITE</code>	the original Colour Maximite's sixteen
<code>MAP GRAYSCALE</code>	sixteen greys, 0 to 255 in steps of 17 (<code>GREYSCALE</code> too)

The two-step is the point, and it is `MMBasic`'s own: applying a new palette one entry at a time shows the picture half recoloured, and `MAP SET` waits for the blanking so the change lands between frames.

`MAP(n)` is also a **function**, giving the colour entry `n` stands for by default — which is the colour a program must ask for to land on that entry:

```
FOR i = 0 TO 15
  LINE i * 20, 0, i * 20, 199, , MAP(i)      ' one line per entry
NEXT i
```

It reports the default and takes no notice of any remapping, exactly as `MMBasic` does; it is the inverse of the fixed rule that turns a colour into an entry number. That rule is bit extraction — one bit of red, two of green, one of blue — and it does **not** depend on the palette, so remapping never moves where new drawing lands.

`MAP` needs a 16-colour mode; in `MODE 1` it is an error.

6.10 Text on the picture: `TEXT` and `FONT`

`TEXT` puts a string at a pixel position, justified how you ask, in any of nine fonts:

```
TEXT 160, 120, "Centred", "CM"
TEXT 319, 0, "top right", "RT", 3
TEXT 0, 100, "big and red", "LT", 5, 2, RGB(RED)
TEXT 0, 200, "over the picture", "LT", 1, 1, RGB(WHITE), -1

TEXT x, y, string$ [, alignment$] [, font] [, scale] [, colour] [, background]
```

Everything after the string may be left out, and a blank argument takes the default, as everywhere in `MMBasic`. `background` of `-1` is transparent, which is how you write over a picture without a box of paper around the letters. With no colours given, `COLOUR`'s are used.

`alignment$` is up to three letters and any of them may be omitted:

	letters	meaning
horizontal	L C R	x is the left, the centre, the right
vertical	T M B	y is the top, the middle, the bottom
orientation	N V	normal, or one character per line downwards

The other three orientations MMBasic offers — I inverted, U and D rotated — are **not yet drawn**; they are accepted and come out normal.

The nine fonts are MMBasic's own, so a character looks the same here as it does there. They live in the PC3's flash, which is why there is no cost to having all of them:

font	cell	what it is
1	8×12	the console's own — the default
2	12×20	
3	16×24	
4	10×16	
5	24×32	
6	32×50	digits only — a clock face, a score
7	6×8	
8	4×6	the smallest
9	8×10	

`scale` is 1 to 15 and multiplies the cell, so font 1 at scale 2 is a 16×24 character built from the 8×12 one.

A character a font does not have prints as a blank cell. With font 6 that is everything except 0 to 9.

`FONT` sets the font `PRINT` itself uses, in a graphics mode:

```
FONT 3, 1
PRINT "large"

FONT [#]n [, scale]
```

This changes where the next line goes as well as how the letters look — a 24×32 font fills the screen in seven lines where font 1 takes nineteen — and scrolling follows it.

6.11 Animation: FRAMEBUFFER

Drawing straight to the screen means the monitor shows the picture half-finished — the erase, then each shape appearing in turn. MMBasic's answer is to build the frame off-screen and show it in one go, and it is here:

```
MODE 2
FRAMEBUFFER CREATE
FRAMEBUFFER WRITE F
DO
  CLS
```

```

CIRCLE x, y, 20, , , 0, RGB(YELLOW)
FRAMEBUFFER COPY F, N, B
LOOP WHILE INKEY$ = ""

```

FRAMEBUFFER CREATE	make the off-screen buffer, blank
FRAMEBUFFER WRITE N F	send drawing to the screen, or to the buffer
FRAMEBUFFER COPY s, d [, B]	s and d each N or F; B starts at the top of the frame
FRAMEBUFFER CLOSE [F]	give the buffer back
FRAMEBUFFER WAIT	wait for the top of the frame

Everything that draws follows WRITE, CLS included — so CLS while writing to F clears the buffer and leaves the picture on the screen alone.

CLS [colour]

fills whatever is being drawn on. With no colour it uses the background from COLOUR, so COLOUR RGB(WHITE), RGB(BLUE) then CLS gives a blue screen; CLS RGB(GREEN) fills with green without changing what COLOUR set. Either way the text cursor goes back to the top left, as MMBasic's does.

CREATE belongs **after** MODE. A mode change throws the buffer away, because what is in it is in the geometry of the mode being left and nothing converts it. That is MMBasic's rule too. You do not have to CLOSE: the buffer comes back automatically when the program ends.

Only one program can hold the buffer at a time — a second one is told so rather than quietly sharing it — and only the program holding it draws into it. Anything else that draws while your program is between frames, a shell prompt included, still goes to the screen.

What it costs. The buffer is in PSRAM, so drawing into it is about 2.4× the cost of drawing on the screen — a full-screen fill measured 1.49 ms direct against 3.63 ms buffered. The copy back is 38,400 bytes at about 53 MB/s, or **0.73 ms**. So a redraw-and-show frame costs somewhere near 4.4 ms against the 17 ms the display gives you, and COPY ... ,B holds the loop to the refresh rate: 59 frames a second, with room for roughly three times as much drawing before one is dropped.

Not yet: FRAMEBUFFER LAYER and FRAMEBUFFER MERGE. There is one off-screen buffer and no transparent blit; both are refused by name rather than translated into something they are not.

INKEY\$ returns the key that has been pressed, or "" if none has, without waiting — which is how the loop above ends. It leaves the terminal as it found it, so INPUT still works afterwards and a program stopped with Ctrl-C does not take the shell's echo with it.

A cursor or function key reaches a terminal as an escape sequence of several bytes, and INKEY\$ reassembles it and gives back the single code MMBasic gives, so the PicoMite idiom works unchanged:

```

DO
  k$ = INKEY$
  IF k$ = CHR$(&H80) THEN PRINT "up"
  IF k$ = CHR$(&H91) THEN PRINT "F1"
LOOP UNTIL k$ = "q"

```

The codes are MMBasic's: &H80–&H83 for up, down, left and right, &H84 insert, &H86 home, &H87 end, &H88/&H89 page up and down, &H7F delete, and &H91–&H9C for F1 to F12. A sequence it does not recognise comes back byte by byte behind its escape, so nothing is lost — and a bare ESC is still CHR\$(27).

6.12 Running another program: SYSTEM, SAVE IMAGE, LOAD IMAGE

SYSTEM runs a program and waits for it:

```
SYSTEM "sum", "a.bmp", "b.bmp"
```

Each argument is passed separately, so no shell quoting is involved and a filename with a space in it needs no special care.

SAVE IMAGE and LOAD IMAGE are built on it — they run the `saveimage` and `loadimage` programs described in the applications list, which means a BASIC program that never touches an image pays nothing for them:

```
SAVE IMAGE "shot.bmp"           ' the whole screen
SAVE IMAGE "part.bmp", 160, 120, 320, 240 ' x, y, w, h
LOAD IMAGE "shot.bmp"           ' at 0,0
LOAD IMAGE "shot.bmp", 160, 120  ' at x,y
```

LOAD IMAGE takes MMBasic's full syntax including the dither mode and the source rectangle:

```
LOAD IMAGE fname$ [,x] [,y] [,mode] [,ximage] [,yimage] [,wimage] [,himage]
```

The decoder is MMBasic's, so it reads 1, 4, 8, 16, 24 and 32-bit BMPs, BI_BITFIELDS, and RLE4/RLE8 compression. Dithering is *optional*, as in MMBasic — omit the mode and the image is mapped without it.

6.13 Music: PLAY MP3, PLAY VOLUME, PLAY STOP

```
PLAY VOLUME 70
PLAY MP3 "/root/mp3/whiter.mp3"
' the program carries straight on, and the music plays
FOR i% = 1 TO 20
  PRINT "still working"; i%
  PAUSE 500
NEXT i%
PLAY STOP
```

PLAY MP3 does **not** wait. The decoder is a separate program feeding a 1.5-second buffer in the kernel, and the sound hardware empties that buffer by DMA, so playback needs nothing from your program once it has started. MMBasic has to refill its audio from the interpreter's idle loop; here there is no idle loop to do it in, and no cost when there is nothing to play. A translated benchmark measured **89% of its full speed** with a track playing.

PLAY VOLUME *n* takes 0 to 100 and is remembered, so every later PLAY MP3 uses it until it is changed again. Out-of-range values are clamped rather than refused. The default is 80. The scale is logarithmic, so 50 is a comfortable half rather than a whisper.

PLAY STOP stops whatever is playing. It asks the kernel which process holds the sound output rather than remembering what it started, so it also stops a player left running by a program that was stopped with Ctrl-C — which is the situation it is most often wanted for. Stopping when nothing is playing is not an error, as in MMBasic.

There is one sound output, so there is one player:

```
Error: sound output in use
```

is what **PLAY MP3** gives if something is already playing. Use **PLAY STOP** first. (This is MMBasic's "Sound output in use for ..." under a shorter name.) The rule is enforced by the kernel rather than by convention: two decoders writing into the same buffer interleave their samples, and it sounds like it.

Files play at their own sample rate — 8 kHz to 48 kHz, mono or stereo, and a mono file costs nothing extra because the driver duplicates the channels itself. Copy MP3s onto the FAT partition from a PC and bring them over with **fat get**, as with any other file.

PLAY and BBC BASIC's **SOUND** share one piece of hardware and are mutually exclusive, exactly as they are in MMBasic. Starting a track silences the synthesiser; stopping it hands the hardware back.

6.14 Pins: **SETPIN** and **PIN**

```
SETPIN 2, DOUT
SETPIN 3, DIN
PIN(2) = 1
IF PIN(3) = 1 THEN PRINT "high"
```

All **forty-eight** GPIOs of the RP2350B are available — the wider part is why the PC3 can put the real-time clock's alarm on GP32, which a 28-pin RP2040 could not reach.

n is the **GPIO number**, not MMBasic's connector-pin numbering. The GPIO number is what the schematic, the kernel, and every other tool on this machine use, and inventing a second numbering for one statement would cause more confusion than the incompatibility does.

SETPIN takes **DIN** and **DOUT**. MMBasic's other modes — analogue, frequency, counting, interrupts — are not translated, and are reported by name.

Nothing stops you claiming a pin that is already in use: there is no reservation list, so **SETPIN 10, DOUT** will happily take a pin the audio hardware is driving and the results will be exactly as bad as that sounds. Appendix A lists what the board uses. A pin number outside 0–47 gives **Invalid pin**.

Every read and write is a call into the kernel — comparable to drawing one pixel, which is over a microsecond. That is ample for a switch or an LED and nowhere near enough to bit-bang a protocol; write that in C, or use the hardware that already exists for it.

6.15 Practical notes

- One **.bas** file per program, because **cc** compiles one file per program. **Subs** and **Functions** all live in that file.
- The C file is a normal file — you can keep it, edit it, or hand it to **cc** on another day.
- **mmbc** and **cc** each need a little room. On a machine with other things running, a large program is happier if you are not also holding a big file open in an editor.
- Programs built this way are the same objects **cc** produces from hand written C, so **bcdump** disassembles them and **BCRUN_BYTECODE=1** forces interpretation for comparison.

7 mmedit: MMBasic's editor

MMBasic's full-screen editor is ported and runs as an ordinary Fuzix program, so BASIC is written, translated, compiled and run without leaving the machine:

```
# mmedit prog.bas
```

It is the editor from the firmware, with the same keys:

Key	
ESC	leave the editor
F1	save
F2	save and exit (so a wrapper can run the program)
F3 / F6	find / find again
F4	mark — then the cursor keys extend the selection
F5	paste
F7 / F8	replace / replace again
F9 / F10	read a file in / write the selection out
F12 or Ctrl-A	beautify: re-indent and case the keywords

In mark mode the legend changes: DEL deletes, F4 cuts, F5 copies, F10 exports the selection to a file. The status line shows line, column and INS/OVR, and the function key legend shortens itself to fit the terminal width.

The editor works over the serial port as well as on the HDMI console — it drives a VT100, and the console emits VT100 function key sequences. Files with CRLF line endings are accepted; the CRs are stripped on load, which matters because most files arrive from a PC.

7.1 The other editor: vi

mmedit is for BASIC. For small text files — a shell script, `/etc/motd`, a short C file — there is a vi:

```
# vi hello.c
```

It is Levee, David Parsons' small vi clone, with modal editing, the `:` commands and the usual movement keys. It has been on the card since the beginning under its own name, `levee`, which still works: `vi` and `levee` are two names for one file.

Its edit buffer is 64 KB, which is enough for any source file you are likely to write on the machine. Levee's own default is 4 KB — it was written for 8-bit micros, where that was a fair share of the machine — and this port raises it, since a process here may have most of a 340 KB pool to itself.

Open something larger than the buffer and Levee says `[overflow]` on the status line and holds the file **read-only**: you can look and move around, but `:w` answers “File is readonly” rather than writing a truncated file back. That is the safe way round, and worth knowing as the signal that a file is too big rather than that something is wrong.

One difference from a full vi to watch: `cw` on the last word of a line joins the following line onto it.

8 The FAT partition and the fat command

Partition 1 of the SD card is ordinary FAT, readable and writable by any PC — this is how files travel to Fuzix, because nothing else can mount the Unix partition. Format it once in Windows (FAT or FAT32, **not exFAT**), then simply copy files onto it.

On the Fuzix side, the `fat` command reads it (long filenames and subdirectories included):

```
# fat info
/dev/hdb1: FAT16, 32695 clusters of 2048 bytes (62 MB)
# fat ls
    4523  My Program.bas
    <dir> BASIC
# fat ls basic
# fat get "my program.bas" /root/prog.bas
# fat get demo.bin                (lowercased name in current dir)
```

`fat` is read-only by design — the desktop does the writing. To move a file *out* of Fuzix, use the serial port, or write it with `doswrite` (the venerable Minix FAT12/16 tool, also included) if the partition is FAT16.

9 Moving files over the serial port

The FAT partition carries files *in*, but **fat** is read-only, so it cannot carry anything back *out*. The serial console can do both, in either direction, with nothing on the board but **uue** and **uud** — and it is the only route that needs no card swapping.

The idea is older than the machine: **uue** turns any file into printable text, and printable text survives a terminal. Both tools are in **/bin**:

```
# uue FILE           writes FILE.uue - the encoded text
# uud FILE.uue       decodes it back, recreating the original name
```

9.1 Sending a file to the board

On the PC, encode the file, then have the board read the text into a file and decode it:

```
# cat > prog.uue      (now paste or send the encoded text)
^D
# uud prog.uue
# ls -l prog.bas
```

The one thing that will bite you is flow control. The terminal input queue is 132 bytes. Sending encoded text as fast as the port will take it overruns that queue and loses characters silently — a 62-character line sent every 25 ms still loses roughly 60% of the text, and the damage only shows up as a corrupt file at the end. Two ways to avoid it:

- **Let the terminal pace it.** Any sender with a per-line delay *and* a wait for the echo will do. The delay alone is not enough.
- **Use the supplied script.** **devtools/uusend.py** in the source tree does exactly this: it types the text one line at a time and waits for each line to echo before sending the next, so at most one line is ever in flight. It then runs **uud** for you.

```
python uusend.py local.bas prog.bas --port=COM11
```

Note that **uusend.py** takes a **bare** remote filename — it drives one **ucp**-style session with **cd** and plain names, so **mv** the file afterwards if it belongs somewhere else.

9.2 Fetching a file from the board

The other direction is easier, because the board is the slow end:

```
# uue report.txt
# cat report.uue
```

Capture the session to a file in your terminal program, cut away anything before **begin** and after **end**, and decode it on the PC.

9.3 Programs to use

Linux (and macOS, and WSL):

- **uue** / **uudecode** come from the **sharutils** package (**apt install sharutils**). macOS has **uue** built in.
- For the terminal, **picocom** (simplest), **minicom** (its **Ctrl-A S** menu includes an **ascii-xfer** that paces lines), or **screen /dev/ttyUSB0 115200**.

- If sharutils is awkward, Python needs no install: `python3 -c "import binascii,sys; ..."` — or just use `devtools/uusend.py`, which does the encoding itself.

Windows:

- **Tera Term** is the pick — free, and its *File* → *Send file* has a per-line delay setting under *Setup* → *Serial port* (set a transmit delay of a few ms per character or 30–50 ms per line). This is the easiest reliable route without scripting.
- **PuTTY** works for capture (*Session* → *Logging*) but has no paced file send; pasting a large file into it will lose characters.
- **RealTerm** can send a file with a configurable delay, and is good at capturing binary.
- For the encode/decode step, Windows has no built-in `uuencode`. Use **WSL** (then it is the Linux instructions), **Python** for Windows, or **UUDevview**, which still builds and runs.

Whatever you use, the check at the end is the same: `sum` the file on both machines and compare. On the board, `sum FILE`.

10 The filesystem and included software

10.1 Layout

/bin	core utilities (always available)
/usr/bin	larger tools, BBC BASIC, fat, picocctl
/usr/games	the games collection
/usr/lib/bbc	BBC BASIC library directory (@lib\$)
/usr/lib/cc	the C compiler passes, and its headers in include/
/usr/man	manual pages (man <name>)
/dev	devices - see below
/etc	rc (boot script), inittab, passwd, termcap
/tmp	scratch space
/root	root's home directory

Key devices:

Device	What it is
/dev/tty1	The console (HDMI + USB keyboard + serial mirror)
/dev/tty2	The GP0/GP1 serial port
/dev/hda	On-board NAND flash filesystem
/dev/hdb1-hdb3	SD card partitions (root is hdb2)
/dev/rtc	The DS3231 clock (<code>setdate</code> reads and sets it)
/dev/sys	Platform control (graphics, sound, ADVAL ioctls)

/etc/rc runs at boot: filesystem check, clock from the DS3231, keyboard layout. Edit it with any of the editors below.

There is no swap device to enable. The PSRAM is not a block device any more: the kernel takes an allocation the size of the process when it needs to swap one out, and programs take their heap from the same place. `free` reports both.

10.2 Applications

Editors: `mmedit` (MMBasic's own full-screen editor — see its chapter), `vi` (levee), `ue` (a WordStar-diamond micro-Emacs: Ctrl-W write, Ctrl-Q quit), `ed`, `fleamacs`.

Shell & core: Bourne `sh` (plus `fsh`), and the classic set — `ls ll cp mv ln rm mkdir rmdir cat more less head tail grep fgrep sed tr cut sort uniq wc find xargs diff diff3 cmp comm join split rev tar dd df du free ps kill killall uptime date cal banner echo sleep tee touch which who su passwd stty mount umount sync fsck mkfs fdisk chmod chown chgrp od hd factor seq units dc expr m4 make cron at mail write wall` (and more — see `ls /bin /usr/bin`).

Machine tools: `picocctl` (keyboard layout, reboot to the flasher), `picogpio/gpiotool`, `gfxtest` (display test card), `setdate` (DS3231), `flashrom`, `setboot`, `dosread/doswrite` (FAT12/16 floppy-era transfers), `fat`, `uue/uud` (serial file transfer — see that chapter).

Images: `saveimage` writes any part of the screen as a 24-bit BMP, `loadimage` puts one back:

# saveimage shot.bmp	the whole screen
# saveimage part.bmp 160 120 320 240	x y w h

```
# loadimage shot.bmp                at 0,0
# loadimage tiger.bmp 0 0 4          with dither mode 4
```

loadimage is MMBasic's BMP decoder, so it reads 1/4/8/16/24/32-bit files, BI_BITFIELDS, and RLE4/RLE8, and dithers only when asked. These are the programs `SAVE IMAGE` and `LOAD IMAGE` run, and they are just as useful from the shell.

Sound: playmp3 plays an MP3 file through the audio DAC:

```
# playmp3 track.mp3                volume 80 by default
# playmp3 track.mp3 40              0 to 100
# playmp3 track.mp3 &              in the background, and carry on working
```

It decodes at about six times real time and takes almost nothing from whatever else is running. This is the program `PLAY MP3` runs, and one plays at a time — a second is refused by name and pid rather than allowed to talk over the first. Stop one with `kill -2` (or, from BASIC, `PLAY STOP`).

Languages: bbcbasic, cc (the on-board C compiler — see its own chapter, with cpp, bcrun and bcdump), fforth (a complete ANS Forth), the as09/ld09 assembler pair, and dc.

Games (/usr/games): the original Colossal Cave `advent`, the complete Scott Adams `adv01–adv14` and Mysterious Adventures `myst01–myst11` collections, Infocom Z-machine interpreters `z1–z8` and `l9x` (Level 9), `startrek`, `hamurabi`, `backgammon`, `invaders`, `2048`, `moo`, `ttt`, `fish`, `arithmetic`, `fortune`, `cowsay`, `wump`.

11 Appendix A: pin usage

GPIO	Function
GP0 / GP1	Serial port <code>/dev/tty2</code> (TX / RX)
GP8 / GP9	System console UART (USB-C CH340)
GP10/11/22	Audio I2S: BCLK / LRCLK / DATA (PCM5102 DAC)
GP12–GP19	HDMI (HSTX)
GP20 / GP21	I2C0: DS3231 RTC and QWIIC connector (SDA / SCL)
GP27	DS3231 32 kHz — board identification (PC3 only)
GP28/30/31/33	SD card, Pico Computer 3 (MISO/SCK/MOSI/CS, SPI1)
GP29/30/31/32	SD card, Pico Computer 2 (CS/SCK/MOSI/MISO, bit-banged)
GP32	DS3231 alarm interrupt (PC3; unused by Fuzix)
GP34–GP37	Joystick switches — <code>ADVAL(0)</code> bits 0–3
GP40	Analogue input (reserved; not read by <code>ADVAL</code>)
GP41–GP44	Analogue inputs — <code>ADVAL(1)</code> – <code>ADVAL(4)</code>
GP45/GP46	Analogue-capable, free
GP23/24/25/29	CYW43 wireless (PC3; unused by Fuzix)
GP47	PSRAM chip select

All spare header pins remain ordinary 3.3 V GPIO. Do not apply 5 V to any GPIO.

12 Appendix B: boot options

The kernel command line (held by the bootloader) accepts:

- `hda / hdb2 ...` — root device override
- `kbd=us|uk|de|fr|es|be` — early keyboard layout override (the layout in `/etc/rc` then applies for the session)

The build, source and development notes live in the `pc3` branch of github.com/UKTailwind/FUZX under `Kernel/platform/platform-rpipico/` — see `PC3-DEVNOTES.md` for the engineering history and `PC3-GFX-DESIGN.md` for the display design.

13 Appendix C: MMBasic coverage

This is what `mmbc` translates today. It is generated from the translator's own tables (`fcc/coverage.py` in the `mmb2c` repository), so it says what the program does rather than what anyone remembers it doing.

Coverage grows with each release, and it will never be complete. MMBasic is a large language whose statements reach deep into one particular firmware, and a translator that emits portable C cannot follow all of it. Anything not listed here is reported by name, with its line number, and the translation continues - so you find out at translate time, not at run time.

13.1 Statements

?	ARC	ARRAY	BOX
CALL	CASE	CAT	CHDIR
CIRCLE	CLEAR	CLOSE	CLS
COLOR	COLOUR	CONST	CONTINUE
COPY	DATA	DATE\$	DIM
DO	ELSE	ELSEIF	END
ENDIF	ERASE	ERROR	EXIT
FILES	FONT	FOR	FRAMEBUFFER
FUNCTION	GOSUB	GOTO	IF
INC	INPUT	KILL	LET
LINE	LOAD	LOCAL	LONGSTRING
LOOP	MAP	MATH	MKDIR
MODE	NEXT	ON	OPEN
OPTION	PAUSE	PIN	PIXEL
PLAY	PRINT	RANDOMIZE	RBOX
READ	RENAME	RESTORE	RETURN
RMDIR	SAVE	SEEK	SELECT
SETPIN	SORT	STATIC	STRUCT
SUB	SYSTEM	TEXT	TIME\$
TIMER	TRIANGLE	TYPE	WEND
WHILE			

Assignment needs no keyword (LET is accepted). Statement separators, line numbers and labels, REM and ' comments all work as expected.

13.2 Functions

ABS	ACOS	ASC	ASIN
ATAN2	ATN	BIN\$	BIN2STR\$
BIT	BOUND	BYTE	CHOICE
CHR\$	CINT	COS	CWD\$
DATE\$	DATETIME\$	DAY\$	DEG
DIR\$	EOF	EPOCH	EXP
FIELD\$	FIX	FORMAT\$	HEX\$
INKEY\$	INPUT\$	INSTR	INT
LCASE\$	LCOMPARE	LEFT\$	LEN

LGETBYTE	LGETSTR\$	LINPUT	LINSTR
LLEN	LOC	LOF	LOG
LTRIM\$	MAP	MATH	MAX
MID\$	MIN	MM.ERRMSG\$	MM.ERRNO
MM.HRES	MM.VRES	OCT\$	PI
PIN	PIXEL	RAD	RGB
RIGHT\$	RND	RTRIM\$	SGN
SIN	SPACE\$	SQR	STR\$
STR2BIN	STRING\$	STRUCT	TAB
TAN	TIME\$	TIMER	TRIM\$
UCASE\$	VAL		

13.3 MATH() sub-functions

Scalar: ATAN3, COSH, LOG10, SINH, TANH

Whole-array (one number out of an array): MAX, MEAN, MEDIAN, MIN, SD, SUM

13.4 Types and structure

INTEGER (64-bit), FLOAT (double), STRING, and arrays of each, up to the dimensions MMBasic allows. DIM, LOCAL, STATIC, CONST, OPTION BASE, SUB and FUNCTION with by-reference arguments, and the usual control flow.

Structures (MMBasic's TYPE ... END TYPE, documented in full in the PicoMite structures manual) are translated with the firmware's byte layout reproduced exactly — STRUCT(SIZEOF "t") answers the same number here and on a PicoMite. Members may be INTEGER, INT, FLOAT, STRING [LENGTH n], arrays of those, or an earlier TYPE; member access works to the full nesting depth (data(2).items(1).values(4) included), structure variables, arrays, LOCALs and by-reference parameters all work, whole structures assign with =, and STRUCT COPY, STRUCT CLEAR and STRUCT SWAP are in. STRUCT(SIZEOF/OFFSET/TYPE) fold to constants when the names are literal strings.

Not translated (each says so rather than mistranslating): STRUCT SORT/SAVE/LOAD/PRINT/EXTRACT/INSERT, STRUCT(FIND), a FUNCTION returning a structure, whole structure arrays as parameters, and initialisers on structure arrays. Assigning a whole structure into or out of a *nested* member is refused deliberately: the interpreter copies the outer type's size there and overruns memory, and a clean error beats reproducing that.

13.5 Errors, and surviving them

Every error a program can hit is a check the runtime makes *before* it does the thing — the same order the interpreter uses. Nothing is left to the hardware to notice: dividing by zero as a float would otherwise answer `inf` rather than stopping, and this processor does not trap integer division by zero at all.

ON ERROR SKIP [n], ON ERROR IGNORE, ON ERROR CLEAR and ON ERROR ABORT work as they do on a PicoMite, with MM.ERRNO and MM.ERRMSG\$ reporting what happened. A statement that fails while an error is being skipped is abandoned where it failed: the assignment does not happen, the rest of the PRINT does not print, and execution resumes at the next statement — in the SUB it happened in, if that is where it was. The count works as it does there too, SKIP n covering the next n statements.

Two limits worth knowing. A statement that jumps away (`GOTO`, `EXIT`) does not count against `SKIP n`, so a count that spans one runs one statement further than it would on a PicoMite. And running out of memory ends the program whatever `ON ERROR` says — there is nothing sensible to carry on with, and a program limping along on a failed allocation would fail somewhere far less obvious.

`ON ERROR RESTART` reboots the machine on a PicoMite; a compiled program has no equivalent, so `mmbc` refuses it by name rather than guessing.

13.6 Not covered

I2C, SPI, one-wire, `PORT`, and the interrupt statements — along with the editor, `RUN`, `LIST`, `EDIT` and the rest of the immediate-mode environment. The hardware statements are the subject of current work; the immediate-mode ones will never apply, since a translated program is compiled and run rather than typed at a prompt. (`mmedit` provides the editing they existed for.)

Of the graphics, `MODE`, `COLOUR`, `PIXEL` (including the array form), `LINE`, `CIRCLE`, `BOX`, `RBOX`, `TRIANGLE` (its drawing form — `SAVE/RESTORE` need the interpreter's blit buffers), `ARC`, `RGB()`, `FRAMEBUFFER`, `PRINT @`, `TEXT`, `FONT`, `CLS [colour]` and `MAP` (statement and function) are done; `BLIT` is not yet, nor are `FRAMEBUFFER LAYER` and `FRAMEBUFFER MERGE`. `TEXT` draws in any of MMBasic's nine built-in fonts but only in its normal and vertical orientations — the three that rotate the character itself are accepted and drawn normally.

Of the pins, `SETPIN n`, `DIN|DOUT`, `PIN(n) =` and `PIN(n)` are done for all forty-eight GPIOs; the analogue, frequency, counting and interrupt modes of `SETPIN` are not.

Of the sound, `PLAY MP3`, `PLAY VOLUME` and `PLAY STOP` are done — `PLAY TONE`, `WAV`, `FLAC`, `MOD`, `MIDI`, `SAMPLE` and `EFFECT` are not, and neither is the four-channel `SOUND` synthesiser the kernel provides to BBC BASIC. `PLAY VOLUME` takes one level rather than one per channel.

In a graphics mode a program's `PRINT` now draws the characters into whatever is being drawn on, as MMBasic does, so text goes into the framebuffer with everything else. What is still missing is `OPTION CONSOLE`, to say whether a program's output should go to the screen, the serial port, or both.